Lab 05: Layered Colour Illustration

Level: Intermediate Suggested time: 75 minutes Platform: Complete the core brief in either Procreate or Sketchbook Studio; use the comparison notes to transfer the workflow. Alignment: K5 | K9 | A2 | LO2

Scenario

A nature education campaign needs a kingfisher-and-orchid illustration that can be recoloured for different seasons.

Your role: Campaign illustrator Required deliverable: A sketch-to-finish illustration with separate line, flat colour, light and texture layers.

Learning goal

Apply Layers | alpha lock or locked layers | clipping logic | flat colour | non-destructive edits to a real design decision and produce evidence that meets explicit acceptance criteria.

Visual reference

!Original course visual

This is an original concept visual generated for this course. Analyse it; do not reproduce it as your submission.

Before you begin

- Use an iPad that supports your chosen app and a compatible stylus where available.
- Save an editable, layered master before exporting a flattened image.
- Use only owned, licensed or clearly permitted reference images and record their sources.
- Create a folder named Lab-05-<YourName> for working files and evidence.

Part A - Plan and construct

1. Review the supplied process visual and define the layer roles: guide, sketch, line, flats, light, texture and accents.
2. Create a 3000 × 2000 px canvas and save it as L05-Kingfisher-Orchid-<YourName>.
3. Construct the bird and flowers using simple forms; correct proportion before clean line work.
4. Create separate flat-colour regions with a limited teal-orange-violet palette.
5. Add shadow and light non-destructively so each can be reduced or recoloured.
6. Add texture only after the silhouette, value hierarchy and focal point are stable.
7. Export four checkpoints-sketch, line, flats and finish-plus the layered master.

Part B - Procreate pathway

1. Create named layers/groups for Guide, Sketch, Line, Flats, Shadow, Light, Texture and Accents.
2. Use Drawing Assist/Symmetry only if it supports the intended structure; switch it off for organic variation.
3. Use ColorDrop on closed shapes for flats and adjust the threshold if colour leaks.
4. Use Alpha Lock for direct colour variation on flats or a Clipping Mask for reversible texture.
5. Set the shadow layer to Multiply only when it produces a physically credible result; lower opacity.

6. Use Screen/Add sparingly for light accents and check material behaviour.
7. Export layer checkpoints using visibility toggles, then save PNG and .procreate master.

Part C - Sketchbook Studio pathway

1. Create separate layers for reference, construction, line, flat colour, shadow, light and texture.
2. Use lock/hide/reorder controls to protect approved stages.
3. Use the fill tool for closed flat-colour regions and the precise eraser to repair leaks.
4. Duplicate a flat-colour layer before applying a filter or blend/opacity change.
5. Use per-layer opacity and blend controls for reversible shadow and light.
6. Use the ruler only for deliberate graphic edges; keep organic forms freehand.
7. Save the layered sketch and export the four stage checkpoints.

Evidence and acceptance checklist

[ ] Layer names reveal purpose

[ ] Line, colour and light can be edited independently

[ ] Palette remains coherent

[ ] Before/after states exported

[ ] Layered working file is saved and opens correctly.

[ ] Final export uses a clear filename and matches the intended dimensions.

[ ] At least one in-progress screenshot shows the technique in use.

[ ] Reference sources and design decisions are recorded.

Peer review questions

1. Which layer separation saved the most rework?
2. Where did colour alter the focal hierarchy?
3. What would break if the file were flattened early?

Debrief

Use the Observe → Interpret → Connect → Propose pattern:

1. Observe: State what is visible without praise or blame.
2. Interpret: Explain the likely effect on attention, meaning, emotion or use.
3. Connect: Link the effect to the brief, a design principle or the acceptance criteria.
4. Propose: Name one specific change and how you will check whether it works.

Record one decision you will keep, one change you will test, and one technique you can transfer to the other app.

Troubleshooting

- The line feels wobbly: Zoom out, slow the decision rather than the stroke, use shoulder movement, and increase stabilisation only enough to preserve intent.
- Colour leaks during fill: Close the contour, inspect gaps at 100%, or place colour on a separate layer and clean with the precise eraser.

- The file becomes hard to edit: Name or document layer roles, hide unused experiments, group related stages and duplicate before merging or filtering.
- The image looks muddy: Check value grouping, lower overlay opacity, remove competing texture and restore one clear focal contrast.
- Perspective feels wrong: Return to horizon and vanishing logic; correct the large box before windows, props or decoration.

Submission package

Submit Lab-05-<YourName>/ containing:

- layered working file (or the app's saved layered sketch);
- final PNG/JPEG/PDF as required by the brief;
- progress evidence/contact sheet;
- short design rationale answering the peer-review questions; and
- reference/provenance list.

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